Mylene Amerol-Macumbal

Mylene I. Amerol-Macumbal is a Filipino jurist and Maranao trailblazer who made history on April 3, 2009, when the Supreme Court of the Philippines released the results of the 2008 Philippine Bar Examinations and her name appeared second on the national list, with an average score of 85.65 percent.<ref name="mindanews2009">Moro woman is 2nd placer in bar exams. *MindaNews*. April 4, 2009. Retrieved from https://www.mindanews.com/c3-news/2009/04/moro-woman-is-2nd-placer-in-bar-exams/</ref>

She was the first Muslim woman from the Bangsamoro to break into the top ranks of the country's most demanding professional examination, finishing just 0.05 percentage points behind the top placer, Judy Lardizabal of San Sebastian College, who scored 85.70 percent.<ref name="legalforum2008">2008 Bar Exam Results: 1,310 New Lawyers. *Philippine e-Legal Forum*. Retrieved from https://jlp-law.com/blog/2008-bar-exam-results-1310-new-soon-to-be-lawyers/</ref>

Her achievement did more than add a name to a topnotcher list. It dismantled a ceiling that had stood unchallenged for decades and showed a generation of young Muslim Filipinos, especially women from Mindanao, that excellence at the national level was not only possible but within reach.

Today, she serves as Presiding Judge of Branch 3 and Acting Presiding Judge of Branch 2 of the Regional Trial Court of Iligan City, and as Vice Executive Judge of the city. Her judicial career has been marked by a child-centered philosophy and a commitment to justice that protects the most vulnerable, particularly children.<ref name="sc_execjudge">Administrative Order No. 140 (2024). *Supreme Court of the Philippines*. Retrieved from https://www.scribd.com/document/792014546/Administrative-Order-No-140-2024</ref>

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Early Life and Background

Mylene Amerol-Macumbal was born and raised in Iligan City, the industrial city in Lanao del Norte that sits at the northern gateway to the Lanao lake country of Mindanao.

Her family roots run deep into the heartland of Maranao territory. Her parents hail from Ditsaan Ramain and Pualas, two municipalities along the western shores of Lanao del Sur, and it is this ancestral connection that forms the cultural foundation of her identity.<ref name="biography_source">Biography of Judge Mylene Amerol-

Macumbal. Unpublished primary source document provided for research purposes, 2024.</ref>

Growing up in Iligan, she was shaped by the intersection of two worlds: the cosmopolitan and multi-faith character of a city built on hydroelectric power and industry, and the deeply traditional Maranao values of her family, including a reverence for scholarship, Islamic faith, and community standing.

Education, for the young Mylene, was never just a path to a career. By her own account, it became an identity. She has described academic excellence as something that turned, from a very early age, into a personal habit, a way of engaging with the world rather than a duty to be discharged.<ref name="biography_source"/>

Education

Mylene completed her elementary education as class valedictorian, an early signal of the intellectual drive that would define her later career.<ref name="biography_source"/>

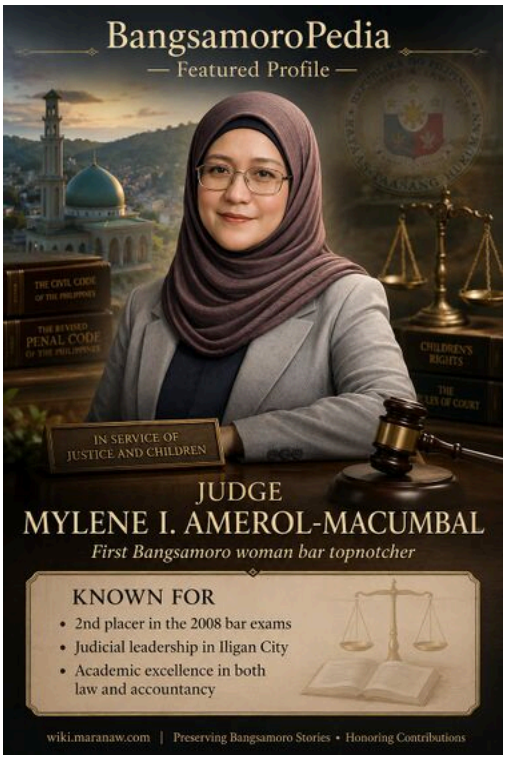
She went on to study at the Mindanao State University-Iligan Institute of Technology (MSU-IIT), one of the premier state universities in Mindanao, where she enrolled in the Bachelor of Science in Accountancy program.

In 2002, she graduated *Magna Cum Laude*, a distinction that placed her among the highest academic performers in her batch.<ref name="biography_source"/>

She did not stop there. Shortly after graduation, she sat for the Certified Public Accountant Licensure Examination administered by the Professional Regulation Commission, placing 18th in the national results, a performance that demonstrated both her analytical capacity and her readiness to compete on the national stage.<ref name="biography_source"/>

Rather than settle into a career in accounting, she redirected her scholarly energy toward law. She enrolled at the MSU-IIT College of Law, an extension program of Mindanao State University, balancing her legal studies with the concurrent demands of teaching, marriage, and motherhood.

After completing her Juris Doctor degree, she continued her academic formation. She has since earned a Master of Laws (LL.M.) from San Beda University in Manila and is currently completing a Doctor of Juridical Science (S.J.D.) at the same institution, making her one of the more academically credentialed members of the Philippine judiciary.<ref name="biography_source"/>

Judge Mylene I. Amerol-Macumbal

Birthplace
Iligan City, Philippines
Heritage
Maranao, with ancestral roots in Ditsaan Ramain and Pualas, Lanao del Sur
Nationality
Filipino
Education
• B.S. Accountancy, Magna Cum Laude, Mindanao State University–Iligan Institute of Technology (2002) • Juris Doctor, MSU-IIT College of Law • Master of Laws (LL.M.), San Beda University • Doctor of Juridical Science (S.J.D.) Candidate, San Beda University
Occupation
Jurist
Current Position
• Presiding Judge, Branch 3, Regional Trial Court, Iligan City • Acting Presiding Judge, Branch 2, Regional Trial Court, Iligan City

The 2008 Philippine Bar Examinations

The story of Mylene Amerol-Macumbal's Bar review is one that law students in Mindanao still talk about, not because it unfolded under ideal conditions, but because of how far from ideal those conditions actually were.

The review period for the 2008 Bar coincided with Ramadan, the Islamic month of obligatory fasting, during which practicing Muslims abstain from food and drink from dawn until sunset each day.

She was preparing for the most consequential examination of her professional life, covering subjects including Taxation, Remedial Law, Commercial Law, Legal Ethics, and Criminal Law, while simultaneously observing the physical and spiritual disciplines of the fast, and doing so as a wife and a mother.<ref name="biography_source"/>

• Vice Executive Judge, Regional Trial Court, Iligan City
Spouse
Judge Arassad Macumbal
Religion
Islam
Notability
First Muslim Bangsamoro woman to place in the Top Ten of the Philippine Bar Examinations; 2nd Place in the 2008 Philippine Bar Examinations with an average score of 85.65%.
Known For
Judicial leadership in Iligan City; child-centered judicial philosophy; landmark ruling on Online Sexual Exploitation of Children (OSEC) cases; academic excellence in both law and accountancy.

When the results were released on April 3, 2009, the name "Amerol-Macumbal, Mylene I." appeared second on the national list of top-ten placers, credited to Mindanao State University, with an average of 85.65 percent. A total of 1,310 candidates passed that year from a field of 6,364 examinees.<ref name="mindanews2009"/><ref name="legalforum2008"/>

The top placer was Judy Lardizabal of San Sebastian College in Manila, who scored 85.70 percent. The margin between them was five hundredths of a percentage point.<ref name="legalforum2008"/>

The remainder of the top ten were drawn almost entirely from Metro Manila law schools, including the Ateneo de Manila University and the University of the Philippines College of Law, making Amerol-Macumbal's second-place finish from a Mindanao state university all the more significant.<ref name="legalforum2008"/>

She was the first Muslim woman from the Bangsamoro to reach the top ten of the Philippine Bar Examinations, a fact that resonated immediately across Mindanao and the broader Muslim Filipino diaspora.

The achievement was notable enough to be cited by President Gloria Macapagal-Arroyo in her State of the Nation Address (SONA) delivered in 2009, where it was presented as evidence of the human capital and untapped potential that Mindanao and its people offered the nation.<ref name="biography_source"/>

> "Academic excellence became a sort of habit."
> — Mylene I. Amerol-Macumbal

Personal Life and Cultural Identity

Mylene Amerol-Macumbal's personal life reflects the texture of contemporary Maranao identity, where deep-rooted tradition and modern professional ambition coexist without contradiction.

She was united in marriage to **Judge Arassad Macumbal** through a parental arrangement, a practice rooted in Maranao custom that she has spoken about with warmth and a measure of humor. Her initial impression of her future husband, who is ten years her senior, was one of gentle bemusement at a man she described as too shy to

court her himself. That first impression proved misleading: Arassad Macumbal, who reportedly placed 9th in the Civil Engineering Board Examination in 1993 before retraining as a lawyer, became one of her most important intellectual mentors and her steadiest source of support throughout her legal career.<ref name="biography_source"/>

Today, the two are known in judicial and legal circles across the Lanao region as the "Macumbal Power Couple," a designation that reflects both the professional standing they have built and the mutual respect their partnership models for younger practitioners in the Iligan City judiciary.

Mylene continues to wear the hijab on the bench, integrating her Islamic practice naturally into her public role as a jurist. In doing so, she offers a quiet but consistent rebuttal to the assumption that Muslim Filipino professional women must choose between cultural authenticity and national participation. Her career and her courtroom presence say plainly that no such choice is required.<ref name="biography_source"/>

Judicial Career

Following her admission to the Philippine bar in 2009, Mylene Amerol-Macumbal began her legal career in the private sector, working at ACCRA Law, one of the largest and most established corporate law firms in the Philippines.<ref name="biography_source"/>

She subsequently transitioned into public service, gaining further experience at the Court of Appeals before pursuing a judicial appointment.

She was appointed Presiding Judge of Branch 3, Regional Trial Court of Iligan City in March 2022, becoming one of the newest members of the Iligan bench at the time.<ref name="manila_bulletin_appt">1 more CA justice, 8 more RTC judges appointed. *Manila Bulletin*. March 10, 2022. Retrieved from https://mb.com.ph/2022/03/10/1-more-ca-justice-8-more-rtc-judges-appointed/</ref>

She concurrently serves as Acting Presiding Judge of Branch 2 of the same court, and under the Supreme Court's Administrative Order No. 140 issued in 2024, she has been designated Vice Executive Judge of Iligan City for the 2024 to 2026 term.<ref name="sc_execjudge"/>

The Supreme Court has also included her among the judges commended for high case disposition ratings, recognizing her efficiency and commitment to clearing court dockets in a region where case backlogs have historically been a challenge.<ref name="sc_commendation">SC names 260 trial court judges commended for high case disposition ratings. *Manila Bulletin*. February 9, 2024. Retrieved from https://mb.com.ph/2024/2/9/sc-names-260-trial-court-judges-commended-for-high-case-disposition-ratings</ref>

Judicial Philosophy

Judge Amerol-Macumbal's approach to the bench is anchored in what she describes as a child-centered philosophy, a principled commitment to placing the dignity and psychological safety of vulnerable complainants, particularly minors, at the center of how judicial proceedings are conducted.<ref name="biography_source"/>

She has consistently argued that the courtroom, as traditionally configured, can itself become a source of secondary harm for child victims when it compels them to relive traumatic experiences before an open proceeding. Her rulings have sought to address this tension directly, using the procedural tools and evidentiary innovations available under Philippine law to achieve accountability without further exposing the vulnerable.

Landmark Ruling on Online Sexual Exploitation of Children

This philosophy found its most concrete expression in a landmark decision Judge Amerol-Macumbal issued in an Online Sexual Exploitation of Children (OSEC) case tried before Branch 2 of the Iligan City Regional Trial Court.

In that case, decided in June 2024, she rendered the decision convicting the accused based on Video-In-Depth Interviews (VIDIs) and digital financial evidence presented by the prosecution, a complete evidentiary record that made it unnecessary for the child victims to testify in open court.<ref name="doj_osec">NCC-OSAEC-CSAEM leads Safer Internet Day 2024 Commemoration. *Department of Justice, Republic of the Philippines*. Retrieved from https://www.doj.gov.ph/news_article.html?newsid=uJPfa8tAqufzJDV8atjhsepkbGf8zNfcYDsEMDv_Mlw</ref>

The decision was recognized by the Department of Justice and allied agencies as a significant step forward in the prosecution of online child abuse cases, demonstrating that OSEC cases in provincial courts can be resolved with full accountability while sparing child victims from further trauma.

Legacy and Cultural Significance

Mylene Amerol-Macumbal's significance to the Bangsamoro extends well beyond any single case ruling or examination score. She has become, in a real and measurable sense, a reference point: a name invoked in the Bangsamoro Parliament when legislators need to make the case that human capital, ambition, and the right institutional conditions can produce extraordinary results from communities that have historically been underserved by the Philippine state.<ref name="biography_source"/>

Her 2009 Bar result has been cited as one of the inspirations behind legislative efforts in the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM) to incentivize and recognize academic achievement among Bangsamoro youth through what has been discussed in parliament under the concept of a Bangsamoro Topnotcher Act, aimed at providing scholarship and recognition frameworks for high-performing students from the region.<ref name="biography_source"/>

More broadly, she represents a convergence of values that are sometimes imagined to be in tension: Islamic piety and Philippine professional life, Maranao cultural tradition and national civic participation, the domestic life of a wife and mother and the public life of a judge and global advocate.

> "Don't be afraid to dream. Study hard, pray harder, and invest in education. It will pay off eventually."
> — Mylene I. Amerol-Macumbal

She describes herself as a "devout student of life," a phrase that captures both her religious orientation and her sustained intellectual curiosity, qualities that have led her from a valedictorian's podium in Iligan, through the top of the national Bar, and to the bench of a Regional Trial Court in the city where she grew up.<ref name="biography_source"/>

Recognition and Awards

- 2nd Place, 2008 Philippine Bar Examinations, with an average of 85.65 percent<ref name="mindanews2009"/>
- 18th Place, Certified Public Accountant Licensure Examination, Professional Regulation Commission<ref name="biography_source"/>
- Cited in the 2009 State of the Nation Address of President Gloria Macapagal-Arroyo as a symbol of Mindanao's potential<ref name="biography_source"/>

- Commended by the Supreme Court of the Philippines for high case disposition ratings, 2024<ref name="sc_commendation"/>
- Designated Vice Executive Judge, Regional Trial Court, Iligan City, 2024 to 2026, per Administrative Order No. 140<ref name="sc_execjudge"/>

Challenges and Perseverance

Amerol-Macumbal's path was not without its difficulties. The decision to pursue law after already establishing herself as a licensed accountant meant starting over in a demanding professional field while managing the responsibilities of family life.

Her Bar review under the conditions of Ramadan fasting stands as the most often cited illustration of the personal discipline her achievement required. That she not only passed but placed second nationally under those circumstances speaks to a combination of preparation, temperament, and faith that her story consistently foregrounds.

As a Muslim woman wearing the hijab on the bench in a predominantly Christian country, she has also navigated the quiet but persistent challenge of visibility: being present in spaces where people who look and dress as she does are rarely represented, and carrying the weight of that representation with composure.

She has spoken about these challenges without dramatizing them, noting that the better response to every obstacle she encountered was simply to prepare more, to pray more, and to keep going.<ref name="biography_source"/>

Further Reading

- Moro woman is 2nd placer in bar exams. *MindaNews*. April 4, 2009. https://www.mindanews.com/c3-news/2009/04/moro-woman-is-2nd-placer-in-bar-exams/
- 2008 Bar Exam Results. *Philippine e-Legal Forum*. https://jlp-law.com/blog/2008-bar-exam-results-1310-new-soon-to-be-lawyers/
- SC names 260 trial court judges commended for high case disposition ratings. *Manila Bulletin*. February 9, 2024. https://mb.com.ph/2024/2/9/sc-names-260-trial-court-judges-commended-for-high-case-disposition-ratings
- NCC-OSAEC-CSAEM leads Safer Internet Day 2024 Commemoration. *Department of Justice, Republic of the Philippines*. https://www.doj.gov.ph/news_article.html?newsid=uJPfa8tAqufzJDV8atjhsepkbGf8zNfcYDsEMDv_Mlw
- Administrative Order No. 140 (2024). Supreme Court of the Philippines. https://www.scribd.com/document/792014546/Administrative-Order-No-140-2024

See Also

- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Maranao people
- Philippine Bar Examinations
- Regional Trial Court of Iligan City
- Online Sexual Exploitation of Children (OSEC)
- Mindanao State University-Iligan Institute of Technology

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